

▲ By The Way...

We've spoken of windows as containing views into documents. It may not be immediately obvious how this applies to the Finder, which actually allows you to directly manipulate your documents in the form of icons. The Finder is a program for manipulating disks and files, so its windows are views into the contents of your disks.

Window Order

If you look closely at Figure 5L, you'll notice that the "Q1" window looks like it's in front of the "Q2" window. And, in fact, the "Q1" window really *is* in front of the "Q2" window. On the Apple Desktop, you work with one window at a time; that window becomes the "frontmost" (or active) window. It's just like having a stack of papers on your desk—you might put the document you're working with on top of the other documents on your desk.

Sometimes the windows don't overlap, so the overlap clue can't always tell you which window is in front. There's another clue, though—the Q1 window also features four black "racing stripes" in its title bar. The title bar is the part of the window that contains the window's name, along with some controls which you'll use to manipulate the window. When you see the stripes, you know exactly which window is ready to go.

To make an inactive window the active window, simply click anywhere in the window. Clicking anywhere in the "Q2" window would bring it to the front and result in the "Q1" window becoming inactive. Some programs, such as the Finder, have a Windows menu that allow you to bring any window to the front easily and quickly—just pull down the menu and choose the window you want to work with.

Opening And Closing Windows

Most programs have an option on the File menu to open documents and to create new documents. Since a window is a view into a document, opening a document opens a window to view the document in. If you choose to open an existing document, you'll first see Standard File Dialog (see Chapter 7) to select the document you want to work on. (In the Finder, you can also double-click an icon to open it.)

When you're done with a document, you can close it. There's usually a Close option on the File menu, but you'll usually find it more convenient to click the close box, the little square at the upper right hand corner of the window.

Moving & Resizing Windows

Desktop windows can be moved anywhere you need them. In our example, it'd be possible to see the complete contents of both windows simultaneously if only we moved the "Q1" window up slightly and moved the "Q2" window down a little bit. That's easy to do via dragging.